

*The Complete Fables*

AESOP

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PENGUIN BOOKS

### *The Ploughman and the Snake Who Had Killed His Son*

A snake slid up to the child of a ploughman and killed it. The ploughman, demented with grief, took an axe and went to keep watch near the snake's hole. He was ready to strike it the moment it came out. The snake poked his head out and the labourer hurled his axe but missed, and instead split a nearby rock in two. Having missed, he was in great fear that the snake would take his revenge on this attack by striking him with his fangs. So he attempted to appease it.

But the snake replied:

'Neither of us can pretend to any good feelings, neither I when I see the gouge you have made in the rock, nor you when you look at the tomb of your child.'

*This fable shows that great hatred does not lend itself to reconciliation.*

### *The Ploughman and the Frozen Snake*

One winter, a ploughman, found a snake stiff with cold. He took pity on it, picked it up and put it under his shirt. When the snake had warmed up again against the man's chest, it reverted to its nature, struck out and killed its benefactor. When he realized that he was dying, the man bemoaned:

'I well deserve it, for taking pity on a wicked wretch.'

*This fable shows that perversity of nature does not change under the influence of kindness.*